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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA OFFICE OF THE PRESIDENT

SUSTAINABLE PROCUREMENT TOOLKIT

University of California, Berkeley
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TOOLKIT

OVERVIEW



This toolkit can be
accessed online at
**[tinyurl.com/Sustainable
ProcurementToolkit](https://tinyurl.com/SustainableProcurementToolkit)**

All of the templates and written
materials mentioned in this toolkit,
plus more, can be found at
tinyurl.com/ToolkitResourceDrive



INTRODUCTION

Where do university dining halls get their food from? Do they prioritize ethical labor practices, humane treatment of animals, or regenerative agriculture? What is a sustainable supply chain, and how can we transform institutional purchasing to align with our values?

These questions sparked our own internal investigation into dining procurement practices at the University of California, Berkeley. Every day, thousands of students rely on institutional dining for their meals. With such immense purchasing power—ordering over 2,000 lbs of food each month—imagine the impact your institution could have on the food system if sustainability and just practices were a priority.

What does institutional purchasing power really mean? It means that when enough people are mobilized to demand better food systems, large institutions and corporations are encouraged to listen. This energy can be leveraged to drive real change in supply chains, demonstrating how reshaping demand can produce better outcomes in supply.

Sustainable dining is more than just an initiative; it's a commitment to reshaping our food systems through trust, not just contracts. Part of securing our food system means growing food where it naturally thrives, ensuring regional economies remain resilient. Transitioning to sustainable procurement isn't just about cost; the real focus is on value. We're not only investing in feeding students ethical and nutritious food, but also truly valuing farmers, ranchers, local jobs, communities, ecosystems, and long-term food security.



PURPOSE

This toolkit is designed to empower students, sustainability professionals, chefs, and procurement teams to take an active role in diversifying their supply chains. It **assumes no prior knowledge** of procurement or sustainability, and is built from the understanding that assessing supply chain sustainability is the **critical first step in building a more transparent and ethical food network**. This resource provides clear, actionable guidelines for auditing campus procurement through quantitative sustainability goals. It equips students and stakeholders with tools to measure their institution's sustainability efforts and advocate for meaningful change.



By using this toolkit, we hope to empower future leaders to investigate and transform their institutions' procurement systems—ultimately working toward a food system that is fair, regional, and resilient.

BACKGROUND

This toolkit was published in August 2025 by undergraduate students working for the University of California (UC) Berkeley Housing and Dining Sustainability Office as a UC-specific tool. It was republished in April 2026 for broader non-UC audiences.

The investigation of Berkeley Dining's distributors and vendors was a project that neatly aligned with the process of updating Berkeley Dining's 20-year-old menu management software during the 2023-24 academic year. By investigating our supply chain, we aimed to incorporate transparency and accuracy into the labels for the new menu management software system, Jamix. These labels would allow us to analyze and automate the calculation of Berkeley Dining's annual sustainable spend, in hopes of increasing the percentage every year.

Part of the internal investigation involved meeting with distributors and vendors. During these meetings, we not only clarified and identified product certifications and sourcing, but we also determined potential alternative products that Berkeley Dining could purchase to transition away from products not meeting sustainability standards.

We hope that this toolkit will guide universities to undergo their own investigation of their supply chain, ensuring improved transparency and values-aligned sustainable spending.



Toolkit authors presenting research in 2025.

GOAL SETTING

Approaching supply chain sustainability is a big task. Our framework breaks this process into three actionable phases. It's important to understand where your institution currently stands in this process and where the entry-points are for individuals trying to improve campus sustainability.

Phase I: Sustainability reporting

- Your institution does not know or report what dining purchases are sustainable or why.
- You may be unsure of who manages procurement and how.
- You do not know what your university considers as sustainable for dining.

Goal of Phase I: Complete annual sustainability reporting for your institution and develop a percentage of sustainable spend.

Estimated duration: 1 semester

Phase II: Internal supply chain investigation

- Someone in your institution has completed annual reporting on campus sustainability and reported a percentage of sustainable purchases (Phase I). However, you may be unsure of its accuracy.
- You may be unsure of who manages procurement and how.
- You may be unsure of what your university considers as sustainable for dining, although somebody on your campus knows.

Goal of Phase II: Investigate the accuracy of internal sustainability reporting by thoroughly auditing procurement. This phase includes meeting with distributors and vendors, and is the main focus of this toolkit.

Estimated duration: 1-2 semesters

Phase III: Increasing sustainable procurement

- Your campus has conducted an investigation into procurement and has confidence in the accuracy of sustainability reporting (Phase II).
- Your campus sustainability stakeholders have developed relationships with internal procurement managers and with sustainable distributors and vendors.

Goal of Phase III: Increase sustainable procurement through strategic, targeted relationships. This can include existing sustainable distributors and other regional recommendations.

Estimated duration: Open-ended.

PART 1

DETERMINE BASIC INFORMATION

PHASE I

What is the purpose of investigating internal procurement?

Campuses across the country are working to serve students more sustainable and ethical food. Usually, there is somebody who is in charge of calculating how much can be considered sustainable. However, it can be hard to do this, which is why it's good to conduct an internal investigation.

PRELIMINARY QUESTIONS

PART 1

These questions are a good first step in your investigation.

Who controls procurement?

Procurement—the process of ordering food and materials for dining services—is typically managed by one or more key staff members. Their titles may include:

- Associate Director of Commodities and Purchasing
- Director of Procurement
- Dining Services Manager

How do they manage ordering?

Ordering systems vary by campus:

- At some universities, a centralized procurement director manages all contracts and purchasing.
- At others, individual chefs or dining managers place orders from a catalog curated by procurement staff.

Understanding your institution's system is key to identifying who makes final purchasing decisions and, in turn, where there may be opportunities to catalyze more sustainable choices.

Do individual dining units order, or is it centralized?

Some institutions allow individual dining units (e.g., dining halls, campus cafés) to order independently using online ordering systems. In these cases, staff may have the ability to choose between conventional and sustainable product options.



MORE QUESTIONS

PART 2



Who has access to menu management software?

Dining teams typically use digital platforms to manage:

- Orders
- Recipes
- Product inventory and stock cards

Common Back of House (BOH) systems include:

- Jamix
- Eatec
- FoodPro
- CBORD

These platforms contain valuable information about what is being purchased, where it's going, and how it's used. Gaining access (or collaborating with someone who has access) can be crucial for accurate auditing.

Who manages sustainability reporting?

Many universities submit annual sustainable procurement reports, or hope to begin doing so soon. This process is often managed by:

- A sustainability coordinator within dining services.
- A dedicated procurement staff member.
- A sustainability office representative.

Who outside of your institution can support you?

Building alliances beyond your university can strengthen your efforts and connect you with best practices across the region. Consider reaching out to:

- Non-dining sustainability professionals at your institution.
- Staff or student fellows at nearby universities working on similar goals.
- Food hubs and nonprofit partners in your region.

These external allies can help provide tools, mentorship, and context to guide your campus efforts.

PART 2

IDENTIFY SUSTAINABLE STANDARDS AGGREGATOR & CRITERIA

PHASE I

THE STANDARDS

When institutions classify food purchases as “sustainable,” they often reference third-party standards aggregators— organizations that compile and validate a list of recognized certifications and sourcing practices. These aggregators provide campuses with frameworks to evaluate whether a purchase meets sustainability goals.

What Is a Standards Aggregator?

A standards aggregator doesn’t certify individual products, but instead defines which certifications count as sustainable. For example, they might recognize USDA Organic, Fair Trade Certified, and Marine Stewardship Council as qualifying standards under their sustainability umbrella.

Two Common Aggregators

The two standards aggregators used within the UC system are the American Association of Sustainability in Higher Education’s Sustainability Tracking and Reporting System (AASHE STARS) and Practice Greenhealth (for medical campuses).



AASHE STARS



AASHE STARS defines what is considered sustainable for procurement at UC Berkeley.

An external, comprehensive set of standards is necessary in an environment where numerous food standards exist with varying levels of legitimacy.

AASHE released STARS 3.0 in June 2024 during UC Berkeley's transition to a new menu management software. Berkeley had previously adhered to STARS v2.2. The new standard includes some meaningful differences that affect Berkeley's sustainability classifications, especially for eggs and seafood.

It's essential when working on university procurement to be familiar with the standards that are applicable under STARS and what kinds of products they apply to. Individuals who are new to sustainability reporting should **take time to learn about common standards under AASHE before beginning a supply chain investigation.**

While STARS is a high-quality, rigorous third party evaluation tool, that does not make it perfect. All standards in the food system have limitations. It is important to be aware of what STARS doesn't cover and where certain standards may fall short. **STARS should serve as a starting point for sustainability on campus, not an end goal.**

THINKING CRITICALLY ABOUT AASHE STARS



**University of California, Berkeley
STARS REPORT**

Date Submitted: Aug. 16, 2018
Rating: Gold
Score: 78.50

While sustainability on campus is numerically determined by STARS, **the true purpose of a supply chain investigation is to quantify and improve institutional procurement as it affects people, animals, and the environment.** In an imperfect food system, not all standards live up to their ideals.

It's essential to acknowledge the limitations of certain standards and think about how to improve institutional procurement, including in ways not reflected by AASHE STARS. As sustainability advocates in dining, **pay attention to how your campus can advance food systems justice**, including on measures that may not be reflected in STARS.

STARS 3.0 REVISED STANDARDS

MEAT

- AGA-Certified Grassfed
- Certified Humane Raised and Handled
- Animal Welfare Approved (A Greener World)
- Global Animal Partnership Certified, Level 3+

POULTRY

- American Humane Certified (Laying Hens - Free Range and Pasture only)
- Certified Humane Raised and Handled
- Animal Welfare Approved (A Greener World)
- Global Animal Partnership Certified, Level 3+
- Label Rouge*
- SPCA Certified*

OTHER AGRICULTURE

- Short Food supply chain
- Small producer
- USDA or CCOF Organic
- Bird Friendly Coffee
- Rainforest Alliance Certified
- Bee Better Certified (Xerces Society) U.S.
- Food Alliance Certified
- Salmon Safe Certified - U.S.
- Fair Trade Certifications (Ecocert Fair Trade (EFT), Fair Trade USA, Fair for Life, Fairtrade International, FairWild, WFTO, Hand in Hand, Small Producers' Symbol, Fair Food Program, Fair Trade Federation)
- Hand in Hand (Rapunzel)
- Small Producers' Symbol (SPP)
- Equitable Food Initiative certified U.S.
- Food Justice Certified (Agricultural Justice Project) - U.S.
- Milk with Dignity (Migrant Justice) U.S.

SEAFOOD

- WWF/Good Fish Foundation*
- Mr. Goodfish seasonal recommendations* NOT US, only International products
- Monterey Bay Aquarium Seafood Watch
- Marine Stewardship Council blue ecolabel
- Ocean Wise Recommended
- Sailors for the Sea Blue list
- Salmon Safe Certified

**ONLY INTERNATIONAL PRODUCTS*

PRACTICE GREENHEALTH



Practice Greenhealth is a nonprofit focused on sustainable healthcare. It provides environmental data services and sustainable procurement guidance to hospitals and health systems. Some universities with medical campuses use Practice Greenhealth's Healthier Hospitals Food Criteria to track sustainable food purchasing.

Standards recognized by Practice Greenhealth overlap with AASHE STARS but include additional health-focused guidelines such as:

- No rBGH (recombinant bovine growth hormone)
- Antibiotic-free animal proteins
- Locally grown or produced food (within 250 miles)
- Certified sustainable seafood (by specific organizations)
- Low-sodium or minimally processed items



SUSTAINABILITY CERTIFICATIONS

We recommend that you familiarize yourself with the standards that your institution accepts and the kinds of products these apply to. While it may seem overwhelming, your conversancy with these standards will develop over time. At the beginning, it is helpful to review standards so you can follow reports and engage in educated conversations about procurement.

Fluency in standards and what they apply to will also help you spot obvious errors in procurement reports. For example, a report may erroneously list strawberries as MSC-certified, which should stand out as incorrect since the Marine Stewardship Council is a seafood certification.



COMMON SUSTAINABILITY CERTIFICATIONS

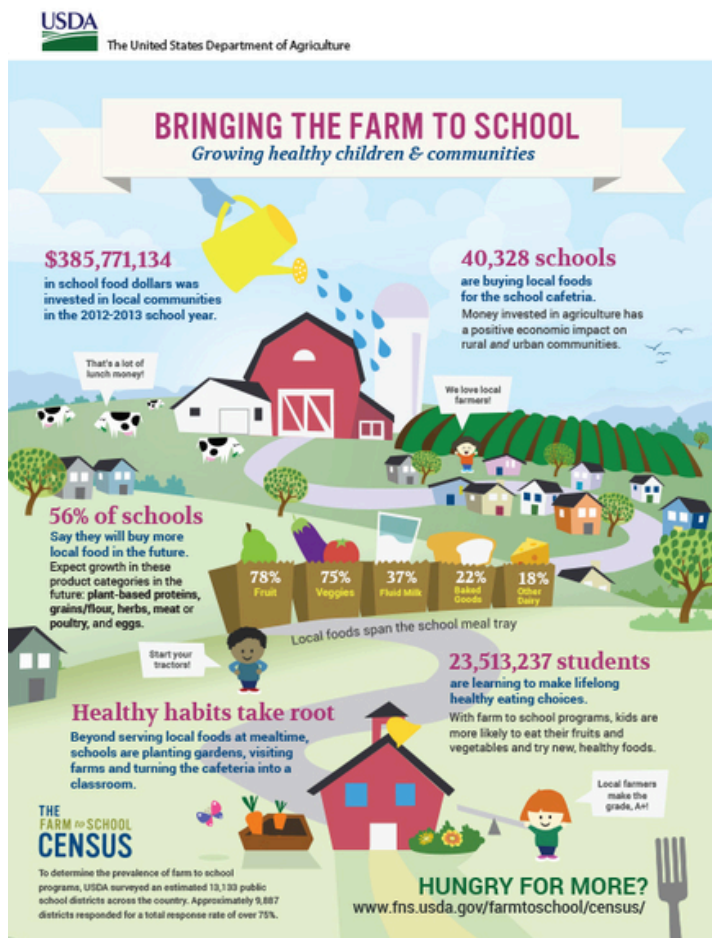
Below is a summary of frequently-cited certifications recognized by STARS and/or Practice Greenhealth. These can be used to classify products in your procurement analysis.

Certification	Recognized By	Description	Applies To
USDA Organic	STARS, PGH	No synthetic pesticides, antibiotics, or GMOs used in production	Produce, meat, dairy, etc.
CCOF Organic	STARS, PGH	Organic certifier under USDA; common in CA food systems	Produce, grains, etc.
Fair Trade Certified	STARS, PGH	Ensures fair labor practices and environmental standards	Coffee, chocolate, bananas
Marine Stewardship Council (MSC)	STARS, PGH	Wild-caught seafood certified for sustainable fishing practices	Fish and seafood
Rainforest Alliance	STARS, PGH	Environmental and social standards for farming and forestry	Coffee, cocoa, produce
Certified Humane	STARS, PGH	Animal welfare certification for meat, dairy, and eggs	Animal products
Global Animal Partnership (GAP)	STARS, PGH	Tiered system for animal welfare	Meat and poultry

WHAT IS “LOCAL”?

What does “Local” mean as a Sustainability Metric?

“Local” food is often seen as more sustainable because it supports regional economies, reduces transportation emissions, and fosters closer relationships between institutions and producers— but the reality is more complex. While local sourcing can offer these benefits, being local alone does not guarantee that a product is environmentally sustainable, ethically produced, or even socially responsible. Therefore, its definition and whether it “counts” toward formal sustainability goals can vary depending on the reporting system your institution uses.



- **Practice Greenhealth (PGH):** Defines local food as grown, raised, or processed within 250 miles of the institution. PGH considers local purchases a qualifying sustainability criterion, especially when paired with attributes like seasonal or minimal processing.
- **AASHE STARS 3.0:** Unlike former versions of AASHE STARS, the latest standard no longer considers “local” as a standalone sustainability criterion. Under the current version, a product must carry a recognized third-party certification (e.g., USDA Organic, Fair Trade) to be counted as “sustainable.”
 - Note: STARS 2.2 previously included local food, which is why some legacy reports may still reference it.

THOUGHTS ON “LOCAL”

Why Local Isn't Always Sustainable...

While buying local food can reduce food miles and support nearby economies, it's not a guarantee of ethical or environmentally sound practices. Here are some key considerations:

- **Environmental Practices:** A nearby farm may still use harmful agrochemicals, heavy machinery, and or rely on monoculture production — all of which can damage ecosystems.
- **Labor Conditions:** Local does not mean fair. Farms within a few miles of campus can still underpay workers, exploit labor, engage in child labor, or fail to provide safe working conditions.
- **Animal Welfare & Inputs:** Animal products sourced locally may not follow humane-handling standards, and the farm may use non-sustainable feed, antibiotics, and enclosed spaces to maximize yields.

Note: If your institution values local food, consider tracking it separately from your formal sustainability reporting. When possible, prioritize local producers who are also Certified Organic, Certified Humane, or meet other third-party sustainability standards.



A “local” Concentrated Animal Feeding Operation near UCB. Not all local farms achieve expectations of humane practices.

TRACKING PLANT-BASED

Measuring sustainability in multiple ways can promote institutional change.

Sustainability in dining can mean many things depending on how it is assessed. One way that UCB determines the sustainability of procurement practices is through annual reporting of plant-based spend. This is an important metric, because animal-based agriculture can have serious environmental costs. **Animal agriculture is responsible for 14.5% of global greenhouse gas emissions¹**, which are an important contributor to global warming and biodiversity loss.

Animal agriculture can also have significant **ethical challenges for human and animal welfare**. Research has shown that slaughterhouse workers face elevated rates of mental health issues, including depression and anxiety, as well as violence-supportive attitudes². There are notable **humane concerns about the welfare of animals** in agricultural systems, as they are often subjected to intense living conditions and show signs of distress³.

As an institution, it is important to promote values-based purchasing while also providing students with options that suit their diverse preferences. Institutional support for providing plant-based choices should seek to **expand the options of students** rather than reducing their access to animal-based products, especially in light of student dietary needs, allergies, and cultural/religious restrictions.



References

- [1] Kristiansen, S., J. Painter, and M. Shea. (n.d.). Animal Agriculture and Climate Change in the US and UK Elite Media: Volume, Responsibilities, Causes and Solutions. Environmental Communication:1–20.
- [2] Slade, J., and E. Alleyne. 2023. The Psychological Impact of Slaughterhouse Employment: A Systematic Literature Review. Trauma, Violence, & Abuse 24:429–440.
- [3] Grandin, T., and C. Shivley. 2015. How Farm Animals React and Perceive Stressful Situations Such As Handling, Restraint, and Transport. Animals: an Open Access Journal from MDPI 5:1233–1251.

PART 3

IDENTIFY DISTRIBUTORS & SUPPLIERS

PHASE I

To effectively increase sustainable food procurement at your institution, it is essential to understand your current food sourcing landscape. This includes identifying the distributors and suppliers your dining program works with.

DISTRIBUTORS & SUPPLIERS



Note: For the purposes of this toolkit, we use “distributor” and “supplier”/ “vendor” to describe organizations providing food products to our campus. However, your institution may use different terms like “farm,” or “producer.” Always clarify local terminology when beginning your research.

Distributors vary in their commitment to sustainability:

- Some specialize exclusively in sustainable, Organic, or local sourcing.
- Others, like Sysco or Daylight Foods, offer both conventional and sustainable product lines. They may offer multiple versions of the same product. For example, Certified Humane and conventional milk.

It is important to assess each distributor’s catalog to determine what sustainable options they currently carry or could carry in the future.

What is a distributor?

A company that purchases food in bulk from producers, and then resells it to institutions such as universities or hospitals. Distributors often manage storage, transportation, and delivery logistics.

What is a broadliner?

A type of distributor that carries a wide range of products—including dry goods, frozen, dairy, produce, and non-food items. Examples include Sysco and US Foods.

What is a supplier/ vendor?

A broader term that **can** refer to both distributors and direct sources, but it is most often used to describe the direct source such as farms, bakeries, or local processors.

HOW TO IDENTIFY

How do I identify my institution's distributors and suppliers?

Start by collaborating with key campus stakeholders (refer to the previous section on "Determine Basic Information")

- Dining services directors or managers
- Sustainability offices
- Any staff reporting for UCOP's annual sustainability reporting

These individuals should be able to provide lists of current contracts, vendor relationships, and sustainability data points.



Case Study: At UC Berkeley, we identified our Dining distributors and suppliers by reaching out to two key stakeholders:

- The Sustainability Procurement Manager, who oversees UCOP's annual summer reporting on sustainable purchases.
- The Dining Procurement Director, who manages food purchasing for campus dining.

EMAIL TEMPLATE

The following is an email template of how you can reach out to a campus stakeholder to request information on distributors and suppliers.

Subject: Request for Information on Current Food Distributors and Suppliers

Dear [Name],

I hope you're doing well. My name is [Your Name], and I'm a [Insert Position (i.e. Sustainable Agriculture Climate Action Fellow)] supporting sustainable food procurement efforts on campus. As part of this work, I'm trying to better understand our institution's current food sourcing landscape—specifically, which distributors and suppliers we work with.

Would you be open to sharing that information or connecting me with someone who may be better positioned to support this effort? If there are any reports used for UCOP's annual sustainability reporting, I'd greatly appreciate the opportunity to review them.

I would also be happy to set up a quick meeting to discuss this further. Thank you so much for your time and support. Please don't hesitate to reach out if you have any questions or concerns.

Best regards,
[Your Name]
[Position Title]
[Contact Info]

HEARING BACK

Once you are in communication with campus stakeholders who have procurement information, you can request procurement reports that include all of the items that your institution purchases. It is likely that these will be in the form of order invoices or spreadsheets, and separated by distributor. Allot time to clean up and organize procurement reports.

Some tips if you have difficulty hearing back from campus stakeholders:

- Send several follow-ups. Campus stakeholders can be busy individuals. If necessary, request help from other campus officials in bumping your email communications.
- Emphasize that you are working internally and will respect the proprietary nature of this information. You do not need price data.
- Reiterate that you are happy to receive reports in any format– spreadsheet, pdf, order invoice– and that you do not expect procurement officials to go through extra work in cleaning or sorting data.



SPREADSHEET ORGANIZATION

It is important to organize the reports that you collect. The following is our “Master Spreadsheet” used to organize information about our distributors and suppliers. See Page 2 for a link to our spreadsheet template.

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	Distributor	Distributor 1	Distributor 2	Distributor 3	Distributor 4	Distributor 5
2	Point of Contact	Sales Representative Name and Email	Sales Representative Name and Email	Sales Representative Name and Email	Unknown	Unknown
3	Master Guide	Distributor Master Guide	Distributor Master Guide	Distributor Master Guide	Distributor Master Guide	Distributor Master Guide
4	Suppliers	Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
5	Green highlight signifies Organic	Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
6	Peach highlight signifies other sustainable certification	Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
7	Never met with these distributors / no contact information available	Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
8		Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
9		Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
10		Supplier name	Supplier name	Supplier Name		
11		Supplier name		Supplier Name		
12		Supplier name		Supplier Name		
13		Supplier name		Supplier Name		
14		Supplier name		Supplier Name		
15		Supplier name		Supplier Name		
16		Supplier name		Supplier name		
17		Supplier name		Supplier name		
18		Supplier name		Supplier name		

- **Row 1** lists the name of each distributor.
- **Row 2** includes the primary point of contact for each distributor.
- **Row 3** links to a master document containing all relevant information we've gathered, such as email correspondence, meeting notes, and additional context.
- **Row 4** lists the suppliers provided by this distributor. Green highlighting indicates suppliers who provide us Certified Organic products. Peach highlighting indicates suppliers offering products with alternative sustainable certifications recognized by our standards aggregator (AASHE STARS).

Note: The tabs at the bottom of the spreadsheet contain detailed lists of products purchased from each distributor. This spreadsheet is a living document that evolves based on our needs, and its structure has been effective in tracking and managing our sustainable sourcing efforts.

PART 4

PRODUCT CLASSIFICATION

PHASE I

Once you've identified which products your institution is purchasing, the next step is to classify them based on sustainability criteria. This process helps you understand which items already meet your institution's sustainability goals and which ones present opportunities for improvement.

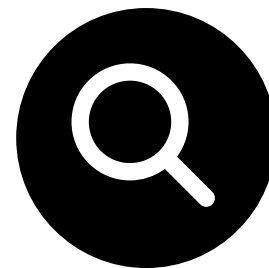
We recommend using a simple spreadsheet to track and classify products. Each row should represent one product, and columns should include details such as:

- Distributor
- Product category (e.g., produce, dairy, meat, packaged goods/snack)
- Supplier
- Product name
- Standard/Certification(s) (e.g., USDA Organic, Fair Trade, Rainforest Alliance)
- Internal product ID
- Sustainable? (Yes/No and NA for non-food items)
- Notes

[illegible]

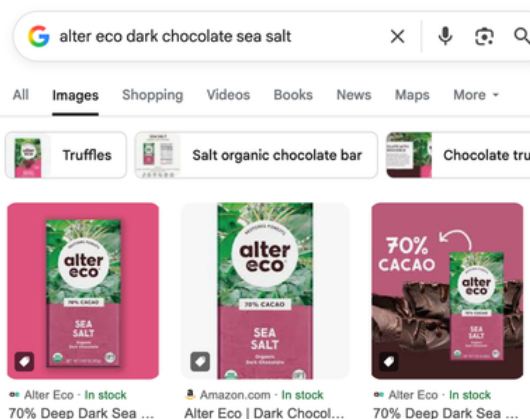
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CHECKING PRODUCT SUSTAINABILITY



How do I know which products are considered sustainable?

Search the product name to check the brand's website or distributor catalog for certification labels or sustainability claims.



Check for official third-party certifications, such as USDA Organic, Marine Stewardship Council, Certified Humane, Fair Trade, etc.

Note: Collaborate with your dining or procurement team to request product specification sheets or sustainability documentation. They may already have this information on file or be able to contact the distributor on your behalf.

PRODUCT CODES & IDS

What are Product Codes?

Distributors associate each product with a code, which they usually share when they send it to your institution. This **code is specific to the distributor** and they will likely ask for it if you are asking them about a specific product. Therefore, it is important to keep track of their product codes in your spreadsheet.

Notice the **"Item #"** (also known as the **Product Code**) in Wonder Ice Cream's purchasing report shared with Berkeley Dining.

Vendor Name: Wonder Ice Cream	
Item #	Product Name or Description
40010	BJ Pt CHERRY GARCIA

What are Product IDs?

Your **university will also assign each product with a unique ID**, which is usually different from the product code that the distributor provided. This ID is important to look up products within your menu management software, and will be important when discussing products with internal procurement officials.

- Keep in mind that the terms code and ID can be used interchangeably. The important thing is to keep track of both, and if they are external or internally generated.

This is Berkeley Dining's unique **Product ID** for the same product.

Ben & Jerrys (B&J) Ice Cream Cherry Garcia Pint (pt) - ID: 341

Save Cancel

Global name* Ben & Jerrys (B&J) Ice Cream Cherry Garcia Pint (pt) Barcode 076840100156 Barcode/sales batch Store Bear Market

Units and suppliers Stock events General Group

Units

Basic unit	Gross	Base unit
EA	= 0.999	lb
	Net	
	0.999	
	Drained	
	0.999	
Sales batch unit		
CS		

Suppliers product information

Supplier Wonder Ice Cream LLC

Supplier's product name Ben & Jerrys (B&J) Ice Cream Cherry Garcia Pint (pt)

Product code 40010

Notice the **Product Code** in Berkeley Dining's menu management software, Jamix, which reflects the product code from above: "40010".

TRACK ASSUMPTIONS

UC Berkeley's Menu Management Software, Jamix.

Stock cards ×

+ Add Open Delete Settings Find duplicate stock card

Search by global name Filter ID

Search by global name ID 341

ID: 341 ×

ID	Global name
3,341	\$Freight/Fuel/Delivery_Almare
3,410	\$Special Item_Beverage_AUI
3,412	\$Special Item_Beverage_Chefs Warehouse
3,413	\$Special Item_Beverage_Daylight
3,415	\$Special Item_Beverage_Peets
3,418	\$Special Item_Beverage_Pepsi
341	Ben & Jerrys (B&J) Ice Cream Cherry Garcia Pint (pt)

Global name * Barcode Barcode/sa

Ben & Jerrys (B&J) Ice Cream Cherry Garcia Pint (pt) 076840100156

Units and suppliers Stock events General

BJ Pt CHERRY GARCIA ID: 341

Reference 602296

Recipe

Nutritive value -

☒ Foodstuff
☐ Contract product
☐ Deactivated
☐ Duplicate
☐ Alcohol
☐ Not included in inventory take
☒ Barcode/sales batch

▼ Linked ingredients

Other additional information

Add notes here.

Note: Keep Track of Assumptions

If you're making assumptions— such as relying on outdated data, previous product names, or indirect information— be sure to document this in a dedicated “Notes” column. These notes can later be revisited with dining procurement stakeholders for clarification.

Alternatively, if you are conducting an internal investigation of distributors and suppliers (see next section), you can direct these questions to the distributor, who should be able to confirm product details and certifications.

Tip: Write down why you marked a product as sustainable, especially if it's based on your own research rather than confirmed data. This will help support future reporting.

HOW TO TRACK PLANT-BASED

UCB tracks plant-based purchasing in institutional dining by calculating the percentage of total spend on plant-based items.

What items count as plant-based?

Plant-based items, also called vegan, do not contain any animal products. This means no meat, seafood, dairy, eggs, honey, or any other animal-derived ingredient. Items with multiple ingredients, such as prepared foods, must be fully plant-based to qualify.

How do you track plant-based spending data?

The recommended spreadsheet format on page 25 of the toolkit, "Organization Template," can also be used to track plant-based spending data. We recommend that you add a column called "Plant-Based," with a YES/ NO/ NA value. Then, you can calculate the column total of institutional spend on items marked YES.

What challenges exist in plant-based tracking?

While plant-based reporting is generally easier than specific certification tracking, it can be sometimes be difficult to determine if prepared and snack foods contain animal ingredients. We recommend caution when using artificial intelligence or keyword-searching to classify plant-based spend, as these approaches can make errors.

PLANT-BASED RESOURCE

A graduate student at Stanford University, Rebecca Grekin, developed an amazing **automated tool that can help your campus calculate plant-based spend** based on dining data. TASTE Food: the Automated Scope 3 Tool for Tracking Emissions from Food, is an online platform where campuses can format and upload their purchasing reports, and they will be automatically labeled with “Plant-Based” using keywords present in the item names. For more information and to access the tool, visit:



<https://food-emissions-categorization.wl.r.appspot.com/>



PART 5

CONTACT DISTRIBUTORS & VENDORS

PHASE II

Once you've identified your distributors and vendors and started classifying products, it is time for Phase II. Reach out directly to key players in the supply chain to fill in information gaps. This will open doors to stronger partnerships and more sustainable purchasing.

WHY CONTACT THEM?

1

Clarify Product Sustainability

Not all product catalogs clearly list certifications. Reaching out allows you to confirm if a product is certified organic (e.g., USDA Organic, CCOF) or meets other sustainability criteria.

2

Understand the Certification Process

Learn how products are certified, which certifying body is used, and how frequently these certifications are updated.

3

Storytelling Sustainability

Some products may not meet AASHE STARS criteria but still reflect values like regenerative practices, BIPOC ownership, animal welfare, or worker fairness. These stories can be used for student-facing education and campus-wide outreach that promote food literacy.

4

Identify New Opportunities & Roadblocks

Suppliers may already carry or have access to more sustainable options— but face cost, distribution, or institutional barriers. These conversations can inform strategic shifts and pilot programs.

5

Build Long-Term Relationships

Establishing trust and open communication with your suppliers makes it easier to gather data, request substitutions, or collaborate on sourcing in the future.

WHO SHOULD YOU CONTACT?

1 PROCUREMENT DIRECTOR

- Before reaching out to distributors and vendors, it's essential to collaborate with your institution's Procurement Director or equivalent decision-maker. These relationships are sensitive and often involve proprietary pricing agreements and long-standing communication channels that are best managed through procurement staff.

2 DISTRIBUTORS

- It's beneficial to reach out to distributors first, and ask them to provide sustainability details for all of the vendors they supply to your institution.
- Reaching out to the distributor first can save you time and energy because they may provide your institution with products from dozens of smaller farms and vendors.

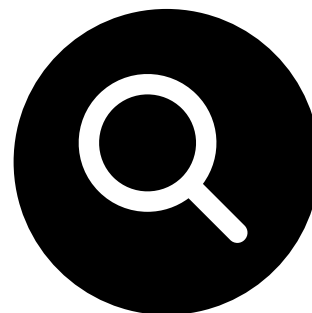
3 VENDORS

- If the distributor is unable to answer all of your questions, ask them for contact information to follow up with individual vendors to answer unresolved doubts.

Below are some of the distributors and vendors UC Berkeley Fellows contacted:



UC BERKELEY CASE STUDY



At UC Berkeley, we first clarified our goals and intentions with our Dining Procurement Director.

After aligning on the importance of gathering sustainability data from our distributors and suppliers, we received the green light to move forward.

Next Steps:

1

Drafted customized email templates and question lists for each distributor we wanted to audit or clarify information with.

2

Shared the drafts with the Dining Procurement Director for review and final approval.

3

Confirmed whether he preferred to send the emails himself (to preserve relationships and leverage existing trust) or allow us to send them directly.

4

Requested that he advise us on who the appropriate contact was at each distributor to ensure the message landed with the right person.

We took this step because working with distributors involves proprietary pricing, product availability, and sensitive internal relationships. Procurement staff—like the Dining Procurement Director—often have direct ties with sales reps and prefer to facilitate communication with them.

EMAIL TEMPLATE

Here's an anonymized version of the email we prepared for distributor outreach:

Subject: Inquiry Regarding Sustainable Product Information

Dear [Distributor Name],

Hello, we are from UC Berkeley's Dining Sustainability office. We're conducting an annual review of Berkeley Dining's sustainable purchases as a part of increasing transparency within our internal operations. Thank you for your support as we currently purchase products from [Vendor name(s)] that we count towards our sustainability goals.

We'd like to speak briefly with someone on your team to clarify and confirm details about the sustainable products we purchase through your distribution. Please note this information is for internal use only and will help us assess and improve our procurement practices.

Let us know a convenient time to meet, and we're happy to share our questions in advance.

Sincerely,
[Your Name]
[Position Title]
[Contact Info]

Tip: Always position your outreach as a collaborative and non-punitive inquiry. Emphasize internal use, appreciation for the partnership, and your goal of improving transparency and shared sustainability goals— not evaluation or blame.

MEETING WITH DISTRIBUTORS AND VENDORS

WE HIGHLY RECOMMEND SCHEDULING A MEETING WITH DISTRIBUTORS AND VENDORS TO DISCUSS SUSTAINABILITY.



Be sure in your meeting to emphasize that you represent an internal sustainability team, and do not give the impression that you are responsible for purchasing or onboarding new products.

Before the meeting, identify products that you would like to discuss with the distributor or vendor. Familiarize yourself with the standards that may be applicable for the kind of products they supply, and the typical audit process for those products.

CONVERSATION OUTLINE

Here is a useful outline for your conversation:

"Our dining team currently purchases the following products

- a. Product common name, external product code
- b. Product common name, external product code
- c...etc.."

"Can you tell us more about the farms/ vendors that supply these products?"

"Do you keep track of their sustainability standards?"

- a. If so, what are they? What agency certifies them? How often are these certifications renewed?
- b. If not, would you be willing to put us in contact, so we can ask the vendor/ farm?"

"We love to share sustainability success stories with our students and highlight the commitment that [distributor name] has to building a more sustainable food system. Are there any initiatives or notable attributes from [distributor name] or [farm/ vendor names] that you think our students should know about?"

- a. This is a great opportunity to focus on other sustainability attributes beyond just what is covered by common sustainability certifications. For example, distributors may share stories about how they incorporate values like regenerative practices, BIPOC ownership, animal welfare, or worker fairness."

ADDITIONAL CONVERSATION NOTES

If the distributor offers both sustainable and conventional product lines, the following question may be appropriate. This can be useful to know for future reference.

"Does your company sell sustainable versions of any products that we currently purchase the conventional version of?"



If there are too many products to discuss individually in a meeting, prepare a spreadsheet ahead of time that includes product names, external product codes, and blank columns for the certification and certifying authority. This will be useful to share and reference in your meeting.

PART 6

REVISE INTERNAL LABELS

PHASE II

After collecting important procurement information from product reports, internal stakeholders, and meetings with external distributors and suppliers, it is time to synthesize these data and revise internal labels. Keep your Master Spreadsheet up to date and note where your information comes from.

AN ITERATIVE PROCESS

As you carefully document all of your meetings, assumptions, and contacts to maintain transparency and accuracy, it is also important to note that revising internal sustainability classifications and maintaining procurement records is an ongoing and iterative process. This is because products may lose or gain certifications, and new purchases are introduced regularly. To ensure that your work remains useful over time and in the future, it's critical to carefully document your process.

Standard Operating Procedures, or SOPs, are a useful tool to ensure the continuation of your efforts for future sustainability stakeholders.

Keeping semi-structured notes, with key details such as

- Point of contact names and contact information.
- Last date of communication or outreach.
- Notes on assumptions made (e.g., labeling something as organic based on a vendor catalog or past report).



Tips to help Track and Update Product Certifications

Because product certifications can change without notice, it's important to:

- Add a "last reviewed" date for each product's certification so that your team can systematically recheck certifications in the future.
- Regularly revisit product entries, especially when procurement teams add new items.
- Request that procurement or IT staff notify your team when new items are added to the ordering platform, so they can be promptly assessed for sustainability status.

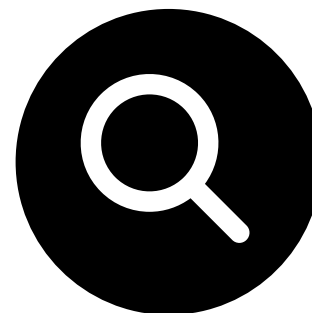
PART 7

DATA ENTRY

PHASE III

Phase III begins with a step to will help your institution keep track of the important information you've gathered. While not part of every sustainable procurement process, we recommend incorporating data entry into your supply chain investigation.

UC BERKELEY CASE STUDY



At UC Berkeley, we began our internal supply chain investigation (Phase II) while our dining operations were transitioning to a new menu management software, Jamix. We used our Master Spreadsheet to add sustainability information to our menu management system.

Essential sustainability objectives with our menu management software:

- Tag each product in a way that allows stakeholders to generate a report including the total “sustainable spend” percentage at the end of the year.
 - Each product must be labeled as Sustainable, Not Sustainable, or Not Applicable (NA). The NA category is important to account for non-food items like gloves or mops purchased by dining.
- Tag each product with the specific certification that makes it sustainable.
 - Some products have multiple certifications (such as Fair Trade and USDA Organic). This tag should therefore be multiple choice, like a checkbox.

Additional information that is useful to track at the product level:

- The lowest-level producer of the product that you know of, and their contact information.
 - For example, the farm that raised the chicken, which was then processed at a secondary site and sold through a distributor.
- Which agency certifies the product.
 - This may also be multiple choice, like a checkbox.
- Frequency of certification.
- When the product was last certified.
- Who last edited the sustainability certification and the date.

Based on these objectives, we worked with the Berkeley Dining and Jamix technology teams and decided to incorporate sustainability labeling in something called stock cards. Within the system of our menu management software, this enables a product-level analysis that achieves our sustainability objectives.

Fair Trade S. America Quinoa Tri Color - ID: 2112

Save Cancel

Global name * Barcode Barcode/sales batch Store

Fair Trade S. America Quinoa Tri Color 000005474431 Crossroads

Units and suppliers Stock events General Groups Sort groups Margin calculation

Sort groups

- Meat certifications
- Sustainable?
 - Yes ☒
 - No ☐
 - N/a ☐
- Poultry certifications
- Seafood certifications
- Sustainable agriculture certifications
 - SFSC: Short Food supply chain ☐
 - SP: Small producer ☐
 - OG: Organic ☐
 - FT: Fair Trade Certifications ☒
 - MWD: Milk with Dignity ☐

Tip: No matter how your menu management software labels products, we recommend meeting with the tech team to discuss your objectives. Dining Directors, Procurement Managers, and even chefs should all be able to put you in touch with individuals who have access to your menu management software.

EMAIL TEMPLATE

Use the following email template to request a connection to individuals who may have advice about how you can incorporate sustainability labeling into internal software.

Subject: Inquiry Regarding Sustainable Product Labeling in [Menu Management Software]

Dear [Stakeholder Name],

Hello, we are from UC Berkeley Dining's Sustainability Team. As part of the UC Office of the President's imperative to report sustainable spending in dining, our team conducted an internal review of Dining procurement.

We would like to incorporate our findings into the existing menu management software, so the product stock cards can contain comprehensive information about their sustainable status. Ideally this would be in the form of three or four tags. This will be beneficial to Dining operations by facilitating easier reporting at the end of the academic year.

We would be grateful for the opportunity to speak briefly with someone on your team to determine how best to implement sustainability tags to the menu management software based on technological constraints. The objective is to add tags which can be sorted and exported with price information to generate a report of total sustainable spending.

Let us know a convenient time to meet, and we're happy to answer any questions in advance.

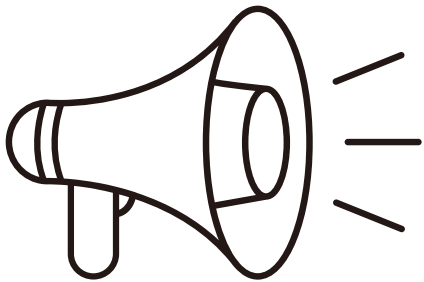
Best Regards,
[Your Name]
[Position Title]
[Contact Info]

PART 8

REFLECTIONS



CRITICAL REFLECTIONS ON SUSTAINABILITY STANDARDS



Through the three-stage investigation of UC Berkeley dining procurement and a comprehensive dive into the world of sustainability certifications, we learned a lot about what these standards mean, and what they don't.

While the purpose of this guide is primarily to help other campuses follow a similar process of increasing their sustainable purchasing per commonly used guidelines, we want to take a moment at the end of this toolkit to acknowledge that there is extensive room for improvement in the robustness of these standards.

Each standard that is part of AASHE STARS or Practice Greenhealth could be individually examined, and both praised and critiqued, in a full-length report of its own. In this reflection, we instead focus on trends that we observed while investigating these standards for ourselves.

Most importantly, we want to acknowledge that environmental sustainability has never been, never could be, and never should be separated from other forms of justice seeking and anti-oppression. The environmental cause is essentially and inextricably bound with racial, ethnic, Indigenous, socioeconomic, gender, queer, disabled, and other struggles.

While “sustainability” labeling can be interpreted to mean many things, there is a mandate within the food system to address current and historical wrongs by actively serving as a promoter of justice– for laborers in the food system, communities impacted by industrial agriculture, Indigenous land stewards, food-insecure communities, and the many other groups who have been unjustly impacted by the food system. This means that institutions, such as universities, should strive to holistically improve their procurement practices with a focus beyond just “environmental” sustainability.

This is already happening in many spaces. Some standards, such as Fair Trade, include commitments mandating fair wages, safe working conditions, and community development support for agricultural producers. But there is much more to be done. Many trailblazing standards, such as the Coalition of Immokalee Workers (CIW) Fair Food program, are not yet included in institutional definitions of “sustainable.”

As a university, we actively strive to incorporate small-scale suppliers; Black, Indigenous, and People of Color suppliers; women-owned suppliers; and immigrant-owned suppliers in our supply chain. While these and many other important factors are not considered within our definition of “sustainable,” it is important to use our institutional purchasing power to uplift underrepresented suppliers where we can.

We also want to acknowledge how privileged we are, as a California-based institution, to be geographically situated near so many incredible farms. For our campus, this means that “local” is not always a particularly telling attribute; there are many local farms that utilize a variety of agricultural techniques, including Concentrated Animal Feeding Operations and intensive cultivation. However, this does not mean that “food miles,” or the distance that a product travels between the farm and your plate, are insignificant. The common standards aggregators discussed in this toolkit do not account for the emissions and associated negative externalities produced by far-flung global supply chains. These can often be quite significant and require a nuanced definition of environmentally sustainable.

Ultimately, although current sustainability standards do not fully address the many systemic injustices in the modern food system, we hope this toolkit will help bring UC campuses closer to achieving food justice. In order to advance access to healthy, affordable, and culturally appropriate food not only for our students, but also for everyone across the supply chain, we must recognize and address the extensive inequalities upstream, ranging from farmers to food service workers who are on the frontlines of this demanding food system.

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QUESTIONS?

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